PACELINE

THE ULTRARUNNER'S PRE-RACE TOOLKIT

Race Day Readiness Checklist

Eight weeks of logistics, pacing, nutrition, crew, and mental prep — condensed into one tactical guide.

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8 WEEKS OUT → RACE EVE

Pre-Race Logistics Timeline

The runners who fall apart at mile 70 usually failed at week 6. Start this checklist the moment you register.

8	3	48h
weeks of prep, broken into clear milestones	critical documents to obtain before week 4	final window — no new gear, no changes

8 WEEKS OUT

- [ ] **Download the official race guide**
  Aid stations, cutoffs, crew-access points. Print it.
- [ ] **Map every crew-accessible aid station**
  Drive times between them. Most crews lose 20–30 min getting lost.
- [ ] **Confirm crew members + assign roles**
  Chief, Logistics, Nutrition. More on page 5.
- [ ] **Build your drop bag list**
  Assign specific items to specific bags. Don't guess race morning.

4 WEEKS OUT

- [ ] **Complete your longest training run**
  Last long run ≥ 3 weeks pre-race for adequate recovery.
- [ ] **Finalize and test all gear**
  Shoes broken in. Vest dialed. Poles — practice with them.
- [ ] **Build your pacing table**
  Projected times at each aid station. Share with crew. (See page 3.)
- [ ] **Practice your nutrition plan**
  Same calories/hr, same products as training. Zero experiments.

2 WEEKS OUT

- [ ] **Deliver crew briefing document**
  Every crew member gets their own copy: arrival times, roles, needs.
- [ ] **Pack drop bags**
  Label clearly. Organize by station. Double-check required gear.
- [ ] **Identify your 3 tightest cutoffs**
  Know exactly how much buffer you have at each one. Calculate now.
- [ ] **Prep your contingency kit**
  Blister kit, anti-nausea, salt tabs. Crew knows where it lives.

RACE EVE + MORNING

- [ ] **Nothing new. Zero exceptions.**
  No new shoes, food, gear, or supplements. Zero.
- [ ] **Sleep by 9pm (even if you can't sleep)**
  Horizontal rest is still rest. Two nights before matters most.
- [ ] **Eat your proven pre-race meal**
  High carb, low fiber, familiar. 3 hours before start.
- [ ] **Text crew exact meeting spot**
  Not "at the aid station" — the specific location.

PACELINE PRO TIP

The two nights before race day matter more than race eve. Most runners sleep poorly the night before — that's normal. Prioritize sleep starting 3 nights out.

02

RACE DAY — MILES 1 THROUGH FINISH

Pacing Rules That Protect Your Finish

The goal is not to run fast — it's to run slow enough that you can still run at mile 80. These rules separate finishers from DNFs.

- [ ] **Rule 1: Start 20–30 sec/mile slower than feels right**
  Early miles feel easy. That's a trap. Your first 20 miles should feel almost embarrassingly slow. Bank nothing. Save everything.

- [ ] **Rule 2: Power hike every significant climb from mile 1**
  Running uphills burns ~3× more energy than hiking at equivalent pace. Walk the ups. Run the downs. Protect your quads for the back half.

- [ ] **Rule 3: Use perceived effort, not pace**
  Elevation, heat, altitude, and fatigue make pace meaningless after mile 40. Target effort 5–6/10 for the first half. Never above 7 before mile 60.

- [ ] **Rule 4: Calculate your elevation-adjusted pace**
  Add 1 min/mile per 100 ft/mile of gain. On steep terrain (>8% grade), add 2 min/mile. Flat pace is irrelevant in mountain ultras.

- [ ] **Rule 5: Never make up time in the first 50 miles**
  Ahead of pace at mile 40? Slow down. You haven't earned those minutes — you've borrowed them at 30% interest, due after mile 70.

TERRAIN	GRADIENT	STRATEGY	PACE ADJUSTMENT
Flat / runnable	0–3%	Run at goal pace, effort 5–6/10	**+0 min/mile**
Gentle climb	3–6%	Run/hike mix, shorten stride	**+1–2 min/mile**
Moderate climb	6–12%	Power hike — do not run	**+3–5 min/mile**
Steep climb	>12%	Slow power hike, use poles	**+6–10 min/mile**
Runnable descent	0–8%	Run, recover here — controlled	**−1–2 min/mile**
Technical descent	>8%	Hike or slow run — protect quads	**+2–3 min/mile**

NIGHT RUNNING (MILES 50–80, TYPICAL)

Add 15–20% to pace targets after dark. Depth perception drops, reaction time slows. Plan for this in your aid station arrival projections — most runners underestimate how much night slows them down.

THE MILE 62 TRAP

Most mid-race DNFs occur between miles 55–70. You're past the halfway euphoria, glycogen is depleted, and you still have a marathon to go. A solid first half buys you the ability to push through this window.

03

MILE 1 THROUGH FINISH — EVERY HOUR

Nutrition Baseline Targets

Start early, eat often, and don't rely on hunger as your signal — it arrives too late to prevent the bonk.

200–300	16–24	400–600	45–60
cal / hour	oz / hour	mg sodium/hr	min interval
Start at mile 1, not when hungry.	More in heat. Adjust to thirst + urine color.	Critical in heat and runs >12 hours.	Eat before hungry. Drink before thirsty.

HOURS 1–6 (EARLY RACE)

- [ ] **Eat within first 30 minutes**
  Your gut is happy now. Train it to accept fuel while moving well.
- [ ] **Stick to familiar foods only**
  Gels, chews, or real food from training. Zero experiments.
- [ ] **Alternate solid and liquid calories**
  Prevents early GI fatigue from sweet gel monotony.
- [ ] **Stay ahead of hydration**
  Urine should be pale yellow. Dark = you're already behind.

HOURS 6–12 (MID RACE)

- [ ] **Shift toward real food**
  Broth, potatoes, quesadillas, PB&J. Gut prefers savory over sweet by hour 8.
- [ ] **Increase sodium intake**
  Especially in heat. Broth at every crew station from here forward.
- [ ] **Don't skip aid stations**
  2–3 minutes eating while walking beats pushing through hungry.

HOURS 12+ (LATE RACE)

- [ ] **Expect appetite suppression — eat anyway**
  Most runners stop wanting food after hour 10–12. Force 150–200 cal/hr minimum.
- [ ] **Caffeine after midnight (or mile 60+)**
  Coffee, cola, caffeinated gels. Don't start too early.
- [ ] **Warm calories = comfort + function**
  Hot broth, ramen, mashed potatoes. Aids morale and digestion in cold.
- [ ] **Small portions, more frequently**
  A nauseated stomach can handle small continuous inputs better.

GI SHUTDOWN PROTOCOL

Stop solid food. Switch to broth + electrolytes only for 30–60 min. Walk. Let stomach settle. Reintroduce with plain crackers. Crew should carry Tums and ginger chews.

04

BEFORE + DURING RACE

Crew Coordination Checklist

Your crew can save your race or cost you it. The difference is almost always preparation. Brief them like they've never crewed before — even if they have.

👑 Chief (Lead Crew)

- Owns the master pacing sheet
- Makes go/no-go decisions
- Manages crew energy and morale
- Final call on pacer deployment
- Never lets runner sit >10 min

🗺️ Logistics (Navigator)

- Pre-drives all crew routes
- Arrives 45 min before runner
- Owns drop bags, staging area
- Tracks runner via GPS/app
- Knows parking, access rules

🍵 Nutrition (Fueler)

- Knows runner's food preferences
- Has warm food ready: broth, potato
- Manages all medical supplies
- Tracks intake across the race
- Pushes food even when refused

WHAT CREW NEEDS TO KNOW

- [ ] **Every crew-access aid station**
  Name, mile marker, your projected arrival time (early/on-time/late).
- [ ] **What you need at each station**
  Different bags, different needs. Create a per-station list, not a generic list.
- [ ] **Your pacer plan**
  Who joins when, which miles, and their role (push / support / navigate).
- [ ] **Your drop criteria**
  What conditions justify DNF. Crew must know — so they don't accidentally talk you out when you're just low.
- [ ] **Emergency contacts + medical history**
  On paper, in their pocket — not just in a phone.

AID STATION PROTOCOL

- [ ] **Arrive 45 min before projected runner time**
  Not 15 min. 45. Parking, staging, and orientation all take time.
- [ ] **Stage everything before runner arrives**
  Warm food ready, shoes accessible, chair out, headlamp charged.
- [ ] **The 10-minute rule**
  No sitting for more than 10 minutes unless medical. Runners who sit get stiff; stiff runners quit.
- [ ] **Positive framing only**
  "You're looking strong" even when they're not. Save honest assessments for genuine safety concerns.
- [ ] **Never ask "how are you feeling?"**
  Ask: "What do you need?" Feelings are irrelevant. Execution isn't.

THE #1 CREW MISTAKE

Being at the wrong aid station. Crew-access points differ from pacer-access points. Know the difference. Drive the route in advance if possible.

05

KNOW YOUR NUMBERS BEFORE RACE DAY

Cutoff Buffer Strategy

Buffer = Cutoff Time − Your Projected Arrival. Calculate this for every timed cutoff before you toe the line.

- Safe: >3 hours buffer
- Watch: 1–3 hours buffer
- Critical: <1 hour buffer

- ☐ **List every cutoff. Calculate your buffer at each one.**
  Do this before race day. If any cutoff shows <1 hour of buffer, rebuild your pacing strategy.
- ☐ **Identify your 3 tightest cutoffs. Know them by name.**
  "I have 90 minutes at Foresthill" is protection. "I'll figure it out" is a DNF waiting to happen.
- ☐ **Fall behind by 20%+ at any cutoff: switch to cutoff mode immediately.**
  Cut aid station time to 3 minutes max. Drop non-essentials. Stop running for enjoyment — run for survival.
- ☐ **Give your crew your cutoff sheet.**
  If you're close to a cutoff and don't know it, your crew should be sending you out the door.

06

MILES 60–80 — THE DARK PLACE

Mental Strategy

Most ultras aren't won or lost on fitness. They're won or lost on the internal conversation between miles 60 and 80.

WHEN: "I WANT TO QUIT"

Sit for 5 minutes. Eat something. Drink something. Then decide. 90% of quit urges pass with calories and rest. Never decide at a low.

WHEN: "I CAN'T KEEP GOING"

"I just need to reach the next aid station." Shrink the goal to 20 minutes. The race doesn't exist — only the next aid station does.

WHEN: PACE HAS DROPPED BADLY

"Forward is forward." Walk it in if you have to. A finish line at 40 hours matters more than a PR you didn't get. Keep moving.

WHEN: EVERYTHING HURTS

"Is this suffering or danger?" Suffering is expected. Danger means stop. Know the difference before you start.

PRE-RACE: WRITE YOUR WHY

Before race day, write down — on paper — your three reasons for being there. Put it in your vest. At mile 70 when your brain is irrational, reading your own handwriting is more powerful than any mantra.

THIS CHECKLIST IS THE FRAMEWORK. YOUR RACE NEEDS THE PLAN.

Get a Personalized Race Guide Built for Your Race

This checklist gives you universal rules. Your race has specific cutoffs, terrain, weather, and crew logistics that need a personalized strategy — not generic advice. Paceline builds that plan in 10 minutes.

WITHOUT PACELINE

- ✗ 30+ hours of spreadsheets
- ✗ Generic advice from Reddit
- ✗ Guessing at cutoff buffers
- ✗ Crew briefed from memory
- ✗ Race-day anxiety

WITH PACELINE

- ✓ 10-minute questionnaire
- ✓ Personalized to your fitness
- ✓ Exact cutoff buffers calculated
- ✓ Crew briefing doc included
- ✓ Race-day confidence

Start Your Personalized Guide

First Ultra Fundamentals $29 · Strava-Powered Strategy $99

paceline.run

"Stop piecing together advice. Start executing with confidence."

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